Stablecoin Insider

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# THE LATAM STABLECOIN ECONOMY 2026

## Infrastructure, Players & the Institutional Opportunity

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MANDIOCA pomelo rise VelaFi MOVANTIS

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# Executive Summary

# Executive Summary

Latin America's stablecoin economy grew out of the broader crypto adoption wave, but what sustains it today is different: stablecoins solved five specific, persistent, measurable problems (inflation, dollar scarcity, remittance costs, rail fragmentation, and underbanking), and the market has visibly reorganised around that utility.

**The evidence now spans every layer:** retail savings, business supplier payments, card spending, payroll, and regulated interbank settlement. Across all of them, the same pattern repeats: stablecoins win on speed, dollar access and working capital efficiency. End users don't think about blockchain, and the last mile into local currency stays on regulated local rails. That is what settlement infrastructure looks like. The operator record assembled for this report confirms the thesis at every layer of the stack.

## Trade Settlement

In trade settlement, Mandioca has processed over $1 billion across 100+ enterprise clients, with more than 90% of volume tied to real trade activity and settlement compressed from 2-5 days to minutes (Source: Mandioca company data).

## Asia-Latam Corridor

On the Asia-Latam corridor, VelaFi recorded 300%+ volume growth in 2025, led by supplier payments and with SMBs now the fastest-growing client segment (Source: VelaFi company data).

## Regulated Settlement

Through its regulated subsidiaries and partners, Transnetwork LLC and its subsidiaries ("Movantis") routes stablecoin and traditional rails through a single integration across a network of 50+ money transmitters and banks, 90,000+ payout locations, and $63B+ in annual volume (Source: Movantis company data).

## Cards Issuance

In cards, Pomelo issues across 170+ clients and 150+ countries with deep roots in Latin America. Banks, fintechs, and crypto companies, settle directly in USDC to eliminate the FX layer for stablecoin-treasury companies, given that domestic card transactions typically cost just 5-15% of cross-border ones (Sources: Pomelo company data).

## Payroll

In payroll, Rise's platform data shows sustained Latam demand for stablecoin payout options, anchored by Argentina, in a global market where stablecoins already account for over 90% of crypto payroll transactions (Sources: Rise company data; Rise Stablecoin Payroll Report).

# The five defining numbers

**Cumulative Latam crypto transaction volume,** Jul 2022 to Jun 2025

**~$1.5 T**

(SOURCE: CHAINALYSIS)

**Share of Brazil's crypto flows that are stablecoin-related**

**90%+**

(SOURCE: CHAINALYSIS)

**YoY growth in global B2B stablecoin payments in 2025, to $226B**

**733%**

(SOURCE: THE DEFIANT)

**Value moved via stablecoins in Latam in 2025 (+89% YoY)**

**$324 B**

(SOURCE: GO MARKETS, CITING CHAINALYSIS)

**Global average cost of a $200 legacy remittance, Q3 2025**

**6.36%**

(SOURCE: WORLD BANK REMITTANCE PRICES WORLDWIDE)

# One takeaway per chapter

### Why Latam

The macro conditions that broke Latam's monetary systems are exactly the conditions stablecoins were built to route around.

### The Market Size

The market has crossed from retail hedging into B2B settlement; supplier payments, not savings, are now the growth engine.

### The Infrastructure

Five distinct layers have professionalised and the last mile still runs on regulated local rails.

### The Ecosystem

Specialised operators now own each layer: trade settlement, enterprise corridors, cards, payroll, regulated networks.

### The Corridors

Three corridor families exist (Latam-US, Latam-Asia, intra-Latam) and stablecoins win each for a different reason.

### CFO & Treasurer Primer

The business case is settlement in minutes instead of days and released working capital, not lower fees.



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# Why Latam

# Why Latin America Is the World's Stablecoin Proof Point

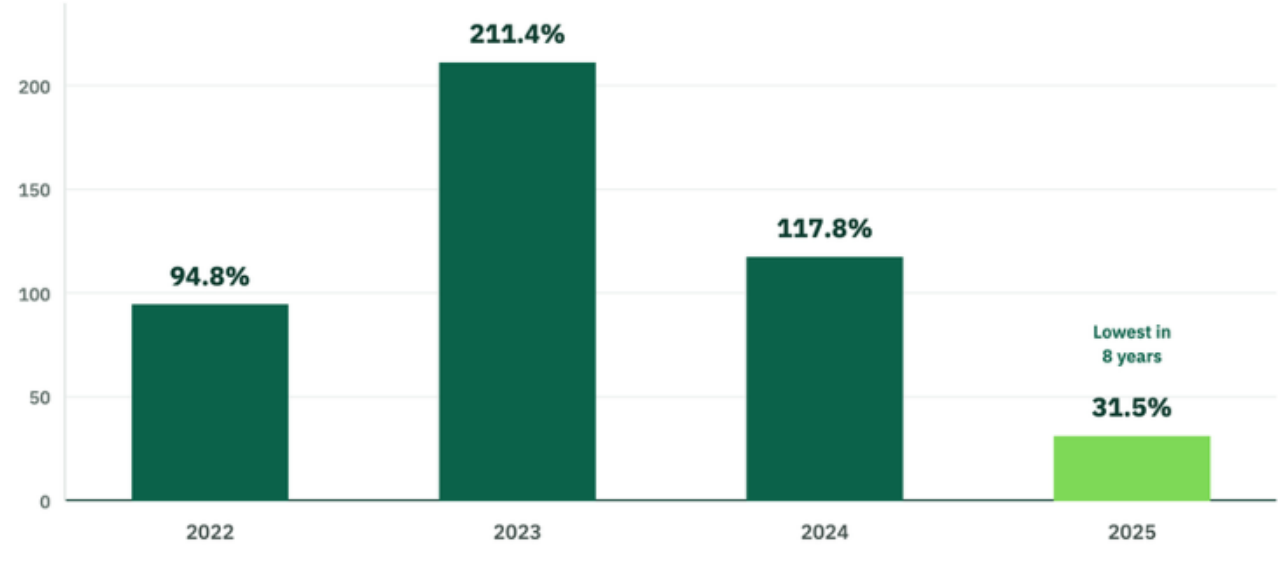
## How does inflation drive stablecoin adoption?

### The Argentina case

Argentina closed 2023 with the world's highest inflation at 211.4%, cut it to 117.8% in 2024, and reached 31.5% in 2025, the lowest reading in eight years (Source: Buenos Aires Herald, citing INDEC). By mid-2026 the rate had ticked back to 33.5% (Source: Trading Economics). Even in its best year in nearly a decade, a peso saver lost roughly a third of their purchasing power. That arithmetic is the foundation of everything else in this chapter: **when the local unit of account fails at its most basic job, demand migrates to whatever instrument holds dollar value with the least friction**.

**Argentina: annual inflation, 2022–2025**

Consumer price index, year-on-year change (%)




Source: INDEC, via Buenos Aires Herald (Jan 2026)

The behavioural response is measurable at every level of the market. **Stablecoins account for over 60% of Argentina's crypto activity,** and the country reached 12% monthly active crypto user penetration in 2025, more than a quarter of all regional activity (Source: GO Markets, citing Chainalysis).

**USDT and USDC made up 72% of all crypto purchases** on the country's largest exchange in 2024 versus just 8% for Bitcoin, and trading activity reliably spikes around salary dates as workers convert pay into digital dollars to preserve value (Source: Dune / Bitso). **Retail-sized stablecoin value received in Argentina has grown faster than any other asset type**, direct evidence that citizens use these tokens to mitigate devaluation rather than to speculate (Source: Chainalysis).

**Inflation reshapes labour markets, not just savings.**

Historically, many skilled professionals in markets like Argentina faced limits when working with international employers because cross-border payment infrastructure was slow, expensive, or unreliable, while global companies were restricted in hiring from the region because of payment complexity and currency volatility.

Stablecoin payroll removes both barriers at once by enabling fast, low-cost, dollar-denominated payments, allowing employers and workers to collaborate regardless of geography (Source: Rise company data).





## Matías Reyes, FIBD Director & Argentina Country Manager, VelaFi, shares with us:

However, reducing the Argentine phenomenon to inflation alone would be incomplete. The underlying issue is less the level of inflation than the volatility in demand for the peso itself, particularly during binary political junctures — 2015, 2019, and 2023 stand out as clear examples — where uncertainty over an electoral or policy outcome triggers an abrupt flight to cover. Historically, this has driven the population toward the dollar as a store of value, amplifying the impact of these discrete events on the monetary system as a whole.

Compounding this, **exchange-rate pass-through to prices during such episodes exhibits an unusually high correlation**: devaluation transmits almost immediately into inflation, further eroding confidence in the local currency. Looking ahead, Argentina faces another such test in 2027, when the next presidential election is due; **the hope is that the economy will be able to absorb this binary juncture without reverting to the sharpest dynamics of past cycles.**

This pattern is not unique to Argentina, either in its past or prospective form; it recurs across other economies marked by structurally high inflation and weak demand for the local currency, **where stablecoins offer a technical workaround to a problem that is, at its root, one of institutional and monetary credibility rather than price levels alone.**

**Venezuela shows what the endpoint of this dynamic looks like after years of hyperinflation and informal dollarization:** the country consistently ranks in the global top 20 for grassroots crypto adoption, and peer-to-peer stablecoin usage is so entrenched that Tron has surpassed Ethereum as its main stablecoin settlement layer (Sources: Chainalysis; Presto Research).

Argentina in 2022, Venezuela over the past decade, and Bolivia today are **the same story at three different stages.**

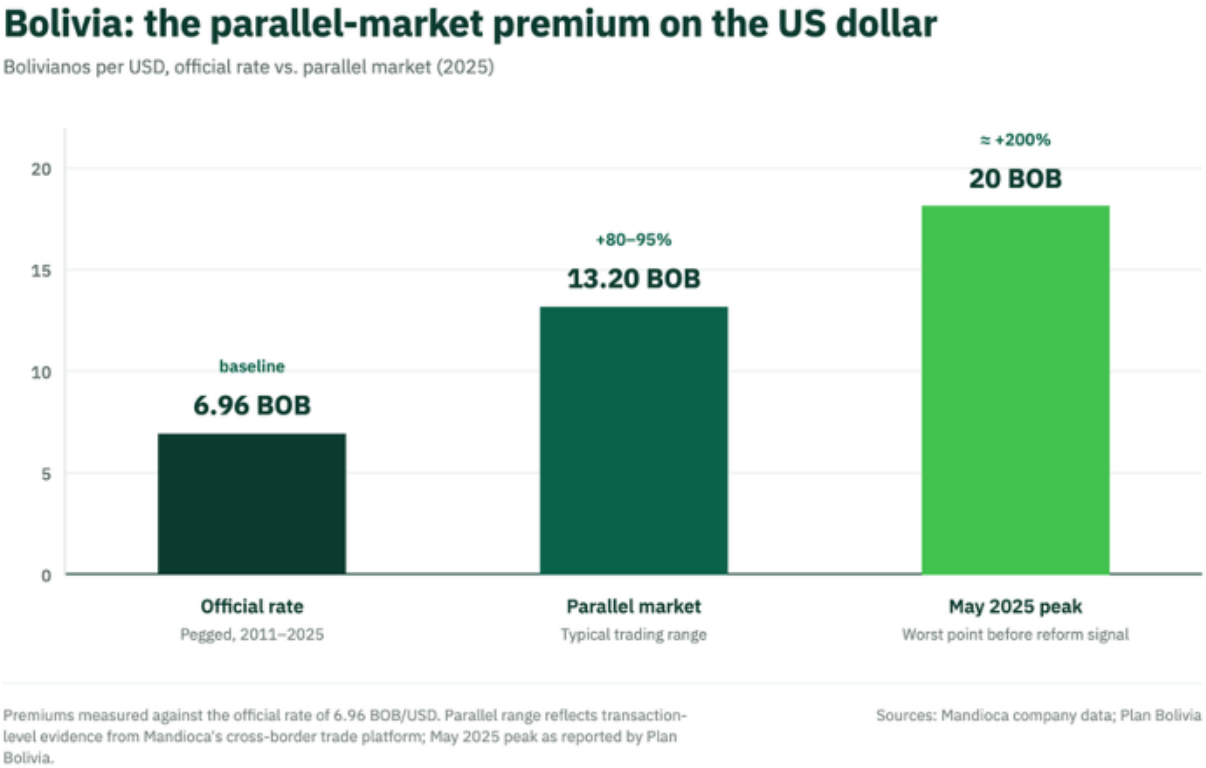


# What happens when a country runs out of dollars?

## The Bolivia case

Bolivia is the region's starkest current example of official dollar channels failing outright. The country held its official exchange rate at 6.86-6.96 bolivianos per US dollar from 2011 until mounting pressure on foreign exchange reserves forced the government to abandon the long-standing peg; the resulting dollar shortage fuelled a parallel foreign exchange market where the dollar traded at a steep premium to the official rate (Source: Cointelegraph, citing Reuters).

**Transaction-level evidence from Mandioca's cross-border trade platform recorded parallel premiums of 80-95% above the official rate,** making dollar access increasingly difficult for any business paying international suppliers (Source: Mandioca company data). At the worst point, in May 2025, the parallel rate was reported near 20 BOB per USD, a premium of roughly 200%, before stabilising after the incoming government signalled a move to a floating exchange rate (Source: Plan Bolivia).



Stablecoins became the workaround, then the policy. **Bolivia recorded $14.8 billion in crypto transaction volume over the twelve months** measured in Chainalysis' 2025 regional analysis, remarkable for a country that banned crypto outright until 2024 (Source: Cointelegraph). **State-controlled Banco Unión began supporting USDT purchases through its Yasta wallet** in April 2026 for international payments and remittances, Banco FIE launched USDT buy/sell through its mobile app, and the Economy Ministry is now formally evaluating a **framework that would recognise USDT as a payment instrument circulating alongside the boliviano and the dollar,** with AML safeguards attached (Source: Coin Insider). A government designing a regulatory framework around a dollar stablecoin, because its businesses already run on one, is the proof-point thesis of this report in a single country.



## FX volatility as a business problem: The Colombia case

Colombia illustrates the softer version of the same condition: volatility rather than scarcity. **The peso moved from roughly COP 3,822 per USD at end-2023 to COP 4,409 at end-2024**, a depreciation of approximately 15% in a single year, enough to materially impact margins and working capital planning for any importer whose suppliers invoice in dollars (Source: Mandioca company data). The retail market responded in parallel with the corporate one: **stablecoins made up 48% of Colombia's crypto purchases in 2024**, aided by restrictions on USD bank accounts and persistent currency volatility (Source: Dune / Bitso). For a Colombian importer, holding working capital in a dollar token between invoice receipt and payment date is not a crypto position, it is **margin protection.**



# Remittance dependence and what it costs

Latin America and the Caribbean received approximately **$163 billion in remittances in 2024**, with Mexico alone accounting for $64.7 billion (Source: World Bank Migration & Development Brief 41, via InternationalMoneyTransfer.com).

In 2025 Mexico's **inflows fell 4.6% to $61.8 billion, the first decline since 2013 and the largest since 2009**, while remittances to the rest of Latin America and the Caribbean grew by more than 16% on average, including Honduras +25.3%, Guatemala +18.7%, El Salvador +17.8%, and Colombia +10.6% (Source: BBVA Research, citing Banxico).

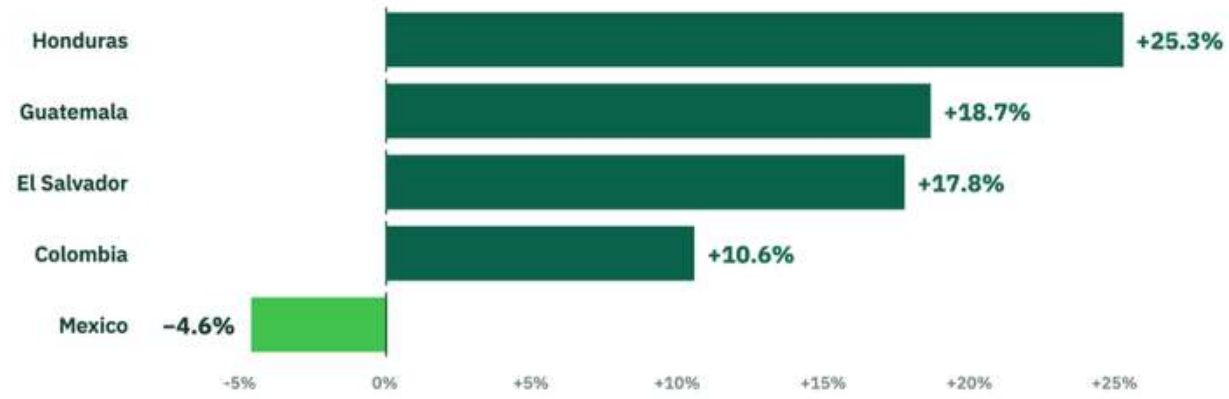
## Mexico breaks from the region on remittances

Change in remittance inflows, 2025 vs. 2024 (%)

**$163bn**
Remittances to Latin America & the Caribbean, 2024

**$61.8bn**
Mexico, 2025 — down from $64.7bn

**2013**
Last time Mexico's inflows fell



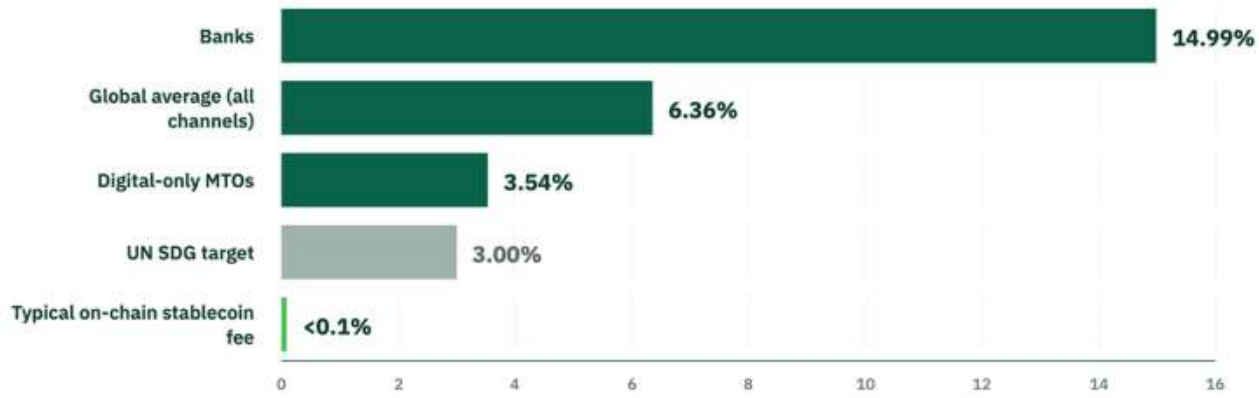

Mexico's 4.6% decline is its first since 2013 and the steepest since 2009; the rest of the region grew by more than 16% on average.

Sources: BBVA Research, citing Banxico; World Bank Migration & Development Brief 41

**Moving that money through legacy channels remains far above policy targets.** The global average cost of sending $200 was 6.36% in Q3 2025; banks, the most expensive channel, averaged 14.99%, and even digital-only money transfer operators averaged 3.54%, still above the UN Sustainable Development Goal target of 3% (Source: World Bank RPW, Issue 54). On the dominant retail stablecoin chain, **the comparable on-chain transfer cost is measured in cents: median fees of roughly $0.09** (Source: Arkham Research). The wholesale leg of the corridor, in other words, has been repriced by two orders of magnitude; what remains costly is the regulated last mile.

### What it costs to send $200 across borders

Average total cost by channel, Q3 2025 (%)




Bank transfers cost roughly five times the UN Sustainable Development Goal target of 3%, and about 150 times a typical on-chain stablecoin transfer fee.

Sources: World Bank Remittance Prices Worldwide, Issue 54; Arkham Research (Tron median fee ≈ $0.09)

## The paradox: fragmented banking, world-class local rails

Latin America pairs weak cross-border banking with some of the best domestic payment systems on Earth:

| SYSTEM | COUNTRY | SCALE (LATEST) |
|---|---|---|
| **PIX** | Brazil | 79.8B transactions in 2025 (up from 63.5B in 2024); R$35.4T moved; 93% of adults |
| **Bre-B** | Colombia | 617M+ transactions in the first six months after its Oct 2025 launch; 218 institutions, 33M users |
| **SPEI / CVU / Bre-B** | Mexico / Argentina / Colombia | National real-time transfer standards |

None of these systems interoperate, and none cross borders. Each country is its own market with different regulatory frameworks, FX controls, and preferred payment methods, and **that fragmentation has been a structural barrier to regional scale for any business operating across markets** (Source: VelaFi company data).

Stablecoins have become the interoperability layer between them: the cross-border leg travels on-chain, and the last mile lands on whichever local rail the beneficiary actually uses. The strength of the domestic rails is therefore not competition for stablecoins; it is what makes the stablecoin model work, because the final disbursement leg is instant, cheap, and universally accepted.

## The underbanked population

Account ownership among adults in Latin America and the Caribbean **rose from 39% in 2011 to 70% in 2024,** real progress that still leaves roughly three in ten adults without a financial account and the region five percentage points behind the average for low- and middle-income countries (Source: World Bank Global Findex 2025, via FinDev Gateway). Mobile money is closing the gap fastest: **37% of adults held a mobile money account in 2024**, up 15 points from 2021, and the **growth of digitally enabled accounts is driving the region's formal savings rate from 18% in 2021 to 29% in 2024** (Source: World Bank Global Findex 2025). Meanwhile, an estimated 57.7 million Latin Americans, about 12% of the population, already held digital currencies by early 2025 (Source: Coinchange).

For a meaningful share of the region, **a stablecoin wallet is the first dollar-denominated account they have ever held.**



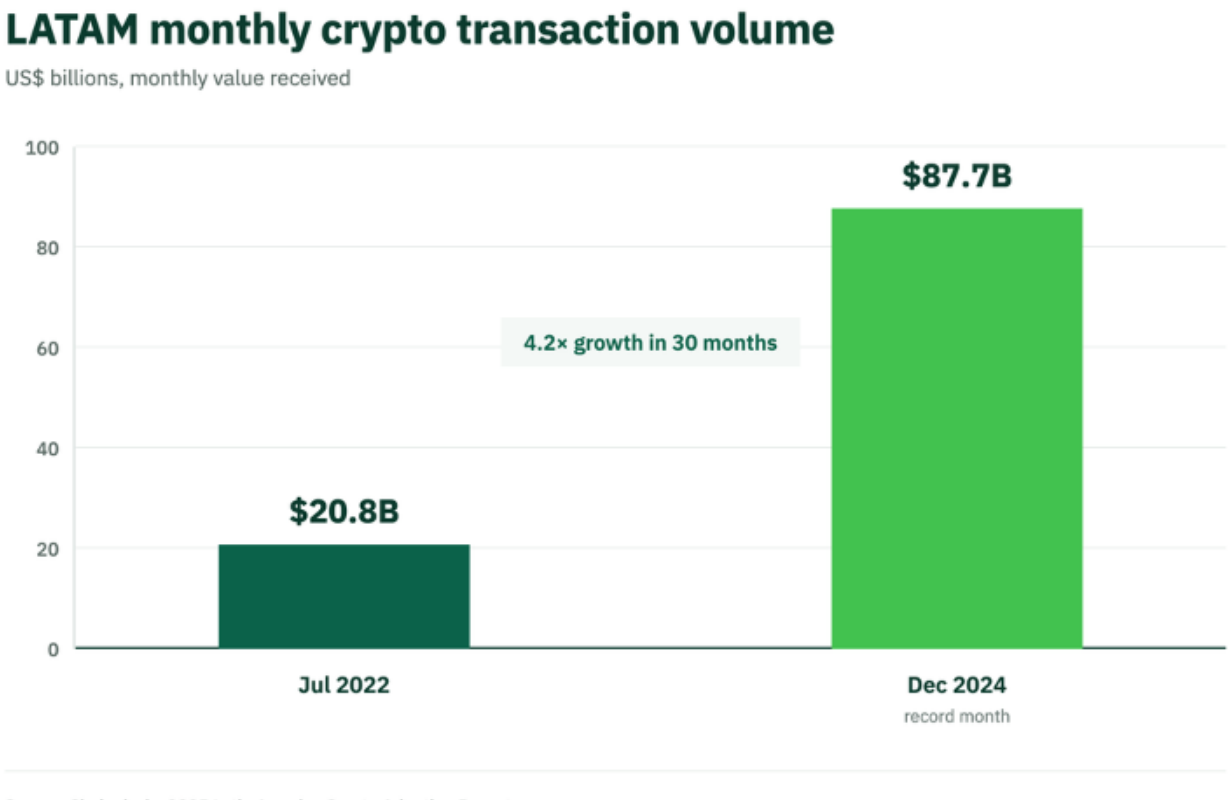
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# The Market Size

# Market Size: The Latam Stablecoin Economy in Numbers

## How big is the Latam crypto and stablecoin market?

Latin America recorded nearly **$1.5 trillion in cumulative cryptocurrency transaction volume between July 2022 and June 2025**, with monthly activity climbing from $20.8 billion in mid-2022 to a record $87.7 billion in December 2024, a more than fourfold increase in thirty months (Source: Chainalysis, via Yahoo Finance). In 2025, **regional on-chain volume rose 60% year-on-year**; of the $730 billion received during the year, $324 billion moved through stablecoin transactions, an 89% year-on-year surge, and monthly active crypto users grew 18%, three times faster than in the United States (Source: GO Markets, citing Chainalysis).




Source: Chainalysis, 2025 Latin America Crypto Adoption Report

**Two structural features distinguish the region from other crypto markets.**

## 1. Stablecoin Purchases

First, stablecoin purchases exceed half of all exchange purchases in countries like Brazil, Argentina, and Colombia, meaning the asset mix is payments-shaped rather than speculation-shaped (Source: Chainalysis).

## 2. Latam Crypto Activity

Second, 64% of Latam crypto activity takes place on centralized exchanges, higher than North America or Europe, which primes the region for infrastructure that seamlessly connects on-chain stablecoin holdings to off-chain spending through cards and local-rail off-ramps (Source: Pomelo company data, citing Chainalysis).

Within the regional total, **the flows split into four working categories**, each mapped to a corridor family in Chapter 5:

- consumer savings and P2P (the retail base built during the inflation years),
- remittances (concentrated on the US corridor),
- B2B trade settlement (concentrated on the Asia corridor and growing fastest),
- institutional transfers (Brazil-led, with institutional and large corporate transfers both growing in excess of 100% period-over-period in the last measured window)

(Source: Chainalysis).